City of Cambridge

POR 2026-173
FIRST IN COUNCIL
September 28, 2026

COUNCILLOR NOLAN
COUNCILLOR AL-ZUBI
COUNCILLOR SOBRINHO-WHEELER

WHEREAS: The 2025 Multifamily zoning was a transformative policy change and is producing many projects that add housing units throughout the city; and the City of Cambridge is seen as a leader in facilitating more housing and addressing zoning that unfairly restricted adding housing units; and

WHEREAS: Concerns about the scale and impact of some of the project, as well as confusion over requirements, edge cases, and interaction with existing City requirements for stormwater retention, green score, and building code merit consideration of amendments now that a year and a half has passed and the zoning has gone through a substantial review, led by the Housing and Neighborhood and Long Term Planning Committees; and

WHEREAS: CDD has presented recommendations on amendments which will help maintain the core concept of enabling multifamily development in all neighborhoods of the city without negatively impacting housing production, but will add clarity to the process, improve objectives for stormwater regulation, green factor, and building code requirements; and

WHEREAS: Amendments include changes to dimensional requirements, which are still more permissive than previous zoning; create clearer standards for green factor, stormwater requirements, and building code regulations; add some incentives to reduce projects with larger unit sizes in a few cases; and clarify textual references that resolve uncertainty within the zoning; now therefore be it

ORDERED: That modeling of the impact of proposed amendments on housing creation by the Community Development Department be presented to the City Council and any proposed amendments be neutral or lead to a net increase in housing units compared to current zoning; and be it further

ORDERED: That no amendments shall be proposed that reduce the amount of affordable, inclusionary housing units that may be built under current zoning; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to work with CDD and relevant City departments to prepare zoning language based on the recommendations discussed in the September 16, 2026 Joint Housing and Neighborhood and Long Term Planning Committees for consideration by the full City Council; and be it further

ORDERED: That the City Manager be and hereby is requested to report back to the City Council in a timely manner.

City of Cambridge

That the City Manager is requested to work with CDD and relevant City departments to prepare zoning language based on the recommendations discussed in the September 16, 2026 Joint Housing and Neighborhood and Long Term Planning Committees for consideration by the full City Council.